1. KWL Activity

Size: Individual, pairs, or small groups

Time: 10-15 minutes

Activity

1. Students are provided with a template or asked to create the template in their notebook. Template is relatively simple to create in one's own notebook and consists of the three sections:

- What they know (K)
- What they want to know (W)
- And what they learned (L)

2. Students complete the “K” and “W” section ahead of class. Instructor asks for examples from class.
3. Following a class, students complete the “L” section. Instructor asks students to provide examples and identifies where their original questions were answered or how any unanswered questions might be addressed in a later class.

Pointers:

- This activity is a way for the instructor to get a general sense of prior learning, and the types of questions, concerns or ideas the students may have.
- This activity can also be adapted by asking students to form pairs or small group and share their answers with another.
- It’s also a great way to generate a list of questions, ideas, or concerns posted by the students to help inform a future class.

2. Dotmocracy

Size: Entire class

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Dotmocracy is a tenique for voting and recognizing levels of agreement among a group of people.

2. For example, in a group discussion, five potential strategies for dealing with a particular problem might be suggested.
3. Students are then each given a certain number of sticky dots, and asked to walk around the room, thinking about each of the options and putting one or more dots on the approaches they most strongly agree with.
4. At the end of the Dotmocracy period, all participants can visually assess the opinion of the group as a whole.
5. Alternatively, students can use markers to add a checkmark or dot as their “Vote”

Pointers:

- This is a great activity to use after brainstorming to assess the interests of the class and focus on one of the issues students highlighted in greater depth later on during the class.

3. Student Panel

Size: Entire class

Time: 20-40 minutes, or longer depending on discussion

Activity

1. Using a central topic or question, gather a panel of student participants that can speak to the topic. Instruct each panel

participant they are to provide a brief overview of their perspective or key points but not to provide all of the details, rather it is up to the class to ask questions.

2. Provide 10 minutes of preparation time the panel participants. While the panel participants are preparing, the class can identify questions with the help of the instructor.
3. Once prepared, introduce the panel and moderate the discussion, encouraging questions from different students, and provide short feedback on the most important issues, questions, ideas relevant to the topic discussed.

Example

- In a business relations class, ask students “What are the key traits of a good mediator?”
- In a hospitality class, ask panel presenters to discuss the different roles within the workplace.
- In a solar installation class, ask panel presenters to each represent a different aspects of a solar installation (e.g. site assessment, client requirements, structure, testing, customer service).

Pointers:

- Instructors can guide the students on the types of questions that would help stimulate discussion.

4. Index Card Pass

Size: Entire class

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Give each student an index card or piece of paper. Ask them to write down one question they have from a reading, or a question more specific to your needs.

2. Students then exchange cards, making at least 4 passes (or more!). If they get their own card back, they can keep it or they can make an extra pass.
3. Have students get in groups of 3-4. Each student should read their index card, and as a group pick one index card question they want to address. Students should then discuss possible answers to the question.
4. After students have had time to discuss, pick a few questions to discuss as a group.

Pointers:

- This activity can run for just part of the class, or as the basis for an entire class. It works well for all class sizes.

5.Think-Pair-Share

Size: Individual and pairs

Time: 1 class

Activity

1. Students individually think about a particular question, scenario, or problem.

2. Next, have each student pair up to discuss their ideas or answers.
3. Then bring students together as a large class for discussion.

Pointers:

- This activity encourages students to think about answers on their own first before talking with other students.
- Avoid asking simple/recall type questions: this activity works best when students are challenged to think through a more complex or complicated idea.
- The benefits of the 3 step process are two-fold: first, students are generally more comfortable presenting ideas to a group

with the support of a partner; second, students' ideas have become more refined through this three-step process.

6. Buzz Groups

Size: Groups of 3-6

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Break class into small groups. Each group discusses the topic or question on their own for a few minutes to generate arguments, answers, or ideas.
2. Once time is up, have each small group share one idea, answer, or argument with the class. Record ideas on the board.

Pointers:

- Keep in mind that the larger the group, the less opportunity each student will have to participate in their small group discussion.

7.One Minute Paper/Reflections

Size: Individual

Time: 1-minute (but really up to 3-5 minutes) at the end of a class or on completion of an assignment

Activity

1. Provide students with one question for brief reflection. Emphasize that responses should be concise.
2. Each student then records and submits their answers.

3. As needed, follow up on comments. Be sure to summarize and respond to any important questions or issues that arise in the students' responses the following class. (e.g. concepts that did not seem clear to students).

Pointers:

- Ending your class with short writing assignments is a powerful way to assess the degree to which students understood the presented material.
- Minute papers can also be used in the middle of lecture components if class concentration begins to wane.
- This is a great activity to use when:

- You encounter a sticky/high-anxiety discussion topic. It allows students to decompress, and reflect on the topic and what happened in discussion.
- Students have just participated in an experiential learning activity, returned from a field experience, or worked on a group project and you would like them to reflect on what they learned from the experience.

Example Questions

What was the most important thing you learned in class today? What questions remained unanswered in your mind today? The clearest point of today was…? Summarize the main point of todays lesson in one sentence. How do you think you will

use what we learned today in your everyday life/day to day work/future career?

8. Case Studies

Size: Small Groups (2-4)

Time: 1 class or long project

Activity

1. Provide the students with a real-world case for the students to study (e.g. a news article, account of a decision or procedure, video, etc.). Alternatively, have students find their own case to examine.
2. Individually, or in small groups, have students analyze the case using guidelines and a framework provided by you (the instructor).
3. Have students present their analysis to the class, or require groups to turn in written answers. If presenting in class, try to facilitate discussion such that students connect the case with material in class.
4. After student analysis has been completed, ensure that the group has concretely discussed how the case study

illustrates application of theoretical or background concepts from course material.

Pointers:

- This is a great activity for students to work on the practical applications of more theoretical or abstract course material. For example, students can come up with pros and cons for two possible options or solutions to a case, utilizing two different perspectives presented in the class to attempt to solve an issue.

9. Complete Turn Taking

Size: Entire class, or small groups (at most 8 per group).

Time: One class (8 questions can be addressed in a 50-minute class).

Activity

1. Each student should be asked to bring a couple of questions to class. These can either be questions to clarify,

issues they think were left unresolved, or ideas or positions not yet considered.

2. Have the entire class arrange themselves in a circle. Alternatively, students can be in small-medium size groups.
3. One student reads a question aloud. The student to their left then has *one minute of uninterrupted time to speak and give their thoughts*. This person signals that they are done speaking by saying, “OK, I’m done.”
4. The next person to the left goes, has one minute of uninterrupted time to speak, and signals they are done by saying, “OK I’m done.” Finally, the third student to the left goes, following the same pattern.

5. After three people have had a chance to speak, the conversation is opened up to the whole group for two minutes of discussion.
6. The next student gets to ask a question, and this cycle continues.

Pointers:

- A benefit of this activity is that it allows students to speak uninterrupted. It also allows the students to work through some of their issues, questions or concerns with the text together.

10. Respond, React, Reply

Size: Small Groups (2-4)

Time: 1 class

Activity

1. Break students up into small groups.
2. Provide students with a prompt. The prompt can be a targeted question, written passage/text, or argument.

3. Each student then responds to the prompt on their own in writing. After each student has had a chance to write their response, have them read and share their response with the group.
4. Each student then reacts to each of the other group members' responses.
5. Then, the student replies to each of the reactions to their own response.

Pointers:

- In creating your prompt, make sure it cannot be answered with a simple “Yes/No.” Try to create questions that will generate discussion.
- Be sure clear expectations and structure are provided to the students (e.g. how long responses/reactions/replies should be, as well as the structure they should take; how this activity will be evaluated; reminders of classroom rules; etc.).

11. Pro-Con Grid

Size: Groups of 2-6

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Pick a topic that lends itself to the idea of making lists of pros and cons/advantages and disadvantages for some issue (see pointers for suggestions). Break students up into small groups.

2. Have the groups come up with at least three points for each side. Additionally, let students know whether they should be putting their lists together in point form or full sentences.
3. Once students have had time to complete the activity, bring the class back together to share and discuss points on each side.

Pointers:

- This activity can help students in developing analytical and evaluative skills. It also requires students to go beyond their initial position and reactions, and come up with points of discussion for the other side of the issue. Finally, it also

requires students to weigh the points of competing positions and clai

12. Think Aloud

Size: Pairs

Time: 1 class

Activity

1. Choose 2-3 paragraphs of new text for students to read.

2. Students work in pairs (student A gets text 1, and student B gets text 2).
3. One student reads a passage of text aloud, and while reading they stop frequently to “think” aloud. The reader stops after every few sentences, and reflects on what they have read. Explain this may feel awkward at first.
4. Model this activity very briefly for students with a sample text.
5. Once student A finishes their text, student B then performs their think aloud. Give students 15-20 minutes to perform this part of the activity.
6. Bring the class back together as a group. Go over each of the texts, then perform a think aloud as a class, asking

students to contribute what they were thinking about at each point.

7. Finally, conclude class with a “Meta-moment”: ask students what they thought of the activity, and what they will take away to their next reading. (This can take the form of a 1-minute paper!)

Pointers:

- At the end of this activity, students will have developed their ability to engage in a close reading of the learning materials and will be able to explain their thinking process.

13. Round Table

Size: Entire class or large small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Have the class move their desks into a circle so that everyone can see each other.

2. The discussion facilitator poses a question. Each person, in turn around the circle, provides a comment. If a student does not wish to comment, they may “pass.”
3. Repeat for a variety of questions.

Pointers:

- This activity ensures that all students have an opportunity to speak if they wish. However, the question posed cannot be a simple yes/no, and must have several points or issues that can be raised.

14. Cumulative Brainstorming

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. The instructor writes a different issue, question, or problem onto four or five large sheets of paper, and then hangs those sheets around the classroom.
2. The instructor asks the students to form groups of about five members each.

3. Each group goes to a different sheet of paper and for three or four minutes they jot down some ideas pertaining to the issue that is written on it.
4. Each group then rotates around to the next sheet of paper and they jot down their ideas pertaining to that issue. They can add new ideas, they can propose counterpoints to the ideas written by the previous group, or they can endorse an idea written down by the previous group by putting a check mark beside it.
5. The groups keep rotating from sheet to sheet until each group has commented on all the issues. Each group then returns to its original sheet and assesses or synthesizes what has been written there.

6. A member from each group reports back to the class as a whole.

Pointers:

This collaborative activity promotes deep learning by encouraging students to build on or critique each other's ideas.

Cumulative brainstorming can also be done in a small group: each student in the group jots down an idea pertaining to a different problem or issue. Each student then hands their sheet of paper to the student on the left (clockwise), who adds an idea or comment to the sheet of paper they have just received.

This continues until all the students have commented on all the sheets.

15. Crowdsourcing

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Tell your students that you will write onto the whiteboard everything they know, or think they know, about

a given topic. You can have them call out the information or, have them raise their hands before speaking.

2. The activity continues until the students can't think of anything further, or until the topic is sufficiently explored for the time being.
3. The instructor then asks the students to organize the information into categories.
4. The instructor then comments on the various pieces of information that students have contributed, making connections, elaborating, and correcting any errors.

Pointers:

This activity helps students feel involved and engaged in the process of accumulating and then synthesizing information.

16. Give one, get one

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Have students fold a piece of paper lengthwise to form two columns and write “Give One” at the top of the left-hand column and “Get One” at the top of the right-hand column.
2. Ask students to brainstorm a list of all the things they already know about the topic they will be studying by writing the items down in the left-hand column. You may want to give them a specific number of bullets to guide the amount of responses.
3. After making the list, have students stand and find a partner. Each person should “give one” of their ideas by saying it out loud. Partners take turns sharing.
4. Have students write any new information they get from these discussions in the “get one” column of their lists, along

with the name of the person who gave them the information.

5. Students should rotate around the room, talking to two or three partners.
6. Once everyone has given and received information, the whole class can discuss the information students have listed.

Pointers:

(Irvine et al, 2006)

This activity is designed to help students access prior knowledge. It promotes connection between students and

allows the teacher to also get some feedback about prior learning.

This activity can be easily scaled up by inviting students to connect with the people in the vicinity of where they are sitting. It will be important to be clear to students how many people they should connect with and the procedure that they should use to determine who to connect with.

17. Exit Ticket

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. At some point during the class, identify a question that you would like to have students answer and let them know that answering this question will be their ticket out the door.

You can even provide them with a small piece of paper that has the question written on it.

2. Remind students before the end of class and then give students a few minutes at the end of class to write their response.
3. Make arrangements to collect the tickets. You might have students place them in a box at the door or, you may want to stand at the door and collect them yourself.
4. As with any learning activity and assignment, teacher feedback is important. It is the essential element to making the activity successful. You must do something with the work in order for the student to know that his effort has been noticed and honored. This could include sending a

summary to students by email or responding to their responses at the beginning of the next class.

Pointers:

This activity is also called an **exit ticket** and it provides an opportunity for the students to give low risk/stakes written feedback to the teacher. It allows the teacher to also get some feedback about student learning and even measure the effectiveness of different learning strategies being used in class.
Follow up by the instructor can happen in the next class.

18. 3-2-1

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

1. Instructor provides each learner with the 3 • 2 • 1 graphic organizer, including prompts e.g., 3 – Important points from

today's lecture. 2 – Limitations of this perspective. 1 – Question I still have is…? Or 1 point that was unclear was…?

2. Learners reflect on the questions posed and record their ideas on the 3 • 2 • 1 graphic organizer (e.g., after viewing a video, listening to a panel presentation or guest speaker, engaging in a service-learning activity, reflecting on a personal experience, etc.).
3. Learners then share their ideas with others (e.g., Think Pair Share-Technique #5).
4. The instructor listens for patterns in the students' responses and uses these to debrief or link to the next part of the instruction.

Pointers:

3 – 2 – 1 is a graphic organizer that learners use to record ideas, observations and/or reflections related to a specific learning experience.

This is an activity that would work well with a larger scale classroom because it involves individual reflection. Students can respond individually in their seats. Students can either share some of their responses in class and/or you can collect their papers as an 'exit ticket', compile their responses and then provide a response to students either online or in the next class.

19. Quiz/Test Questions

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: Unrestricted

Activity

Students are asked to become actively involved in the creation of tests and quizzes. The examples they come up with maybe assigned for extra value or used on a regular class schedule to provide feedback to the student regarding whether they

understand the content or not. In asking students to think up exam questions, we encourage them to think more deeply about the course material and to explore major themes, comparison of views presented, applications, and other higher-order thinking skills.

Beyond simply using example questions as a quiz or test, ask the students to evaluate the question submitted; in discussing questions, they will significantly increase their engagement of the material to supply answers. Students might be asked to discuss several aspects of two different questions on the same material including degree of difficulty, effectiveness in assessing their learning, proper scope of questions, and so forth.

Pointers:

This activity can be adapted for large scale classrooms with the use of small groups. Small groups can work together to generate the questions. The small groups can share with the larger groups either by sharing in the larger group or by posting their questions to an online discussion board. Follow up by the instructor can happen in the next class or online through a generation of a composite document.

20. Jigsaw

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 30-45 minutes

Activity

1. Instructor selects articles, excerpts from books or other text appropriate to course content. Provide one reading per person, or longer articles can be divided into appropriate sections.

2. Divide the students into small Cooperative Jigsaw groups (e.g., 3-6 persons in each group).
3. Have each member of the Cooperative Jigsaw group silently read the text assigned. Each person will have a different reading. Time: 5-10 minutes.
4. Create new small (2-3) “Expert” groups with the individuals who have read the same material. Allow time for learners to discuss what they have read and how they might teach this when they return to their Cooperative groups. Time: 5-10 minutes.
5. Recreate the original Cooperative Jigsaw groups. Have each person teach the rest of the group the material from the text read. Time: 5 minutes / person.

6. Conclude with a key question(s) for the groups or discuss applications or implications of the ideas within the groups or with the entire class. Maybe combined with other take-up evaluation techniques to ensure that individuals understand the content.

Pointers:

A jigsaw provides a way for students to learn new content and also provides an opportunity for them to teach each other what they have learned and discuss implications of the reading.

21. Flash Review

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 30-45 minutes

Activity

1. Create a list of 10-15 questions based on major themes/ideas of course content.
2. Integrate the open-ended questions into a simple PowerPoint Presentation and set the slides to transition at a 20 (to 30) second interval.

3. Instruct students to get into pairs and to discuss the correct answer for each question as it emerges.
4. While the slides are progressing, circulate through the classroom and listen to the discussion that the students are having about each question. Make a note of places where they are having difficulty, where there are blockages.
5. Back in the larger group, ask students to share the ‘answers’ and to indicate areas where they feel that they need clarification.
6. Address the areas that they need clarification from what they have shared and/or from what you heard while you were circulating.

7. Follow up with a list of the questions and the answers generated through the activity, as well as areas for further support and send the materials to students as an email or post them online.

Pointers:

It can sometimes be difficult to gauge the different areas that students need clarification on. This activity provides you with an opportunity as an instructor to determine different areas of the course content that are causing ‘blockages’ for students. Once the blockages have been determined, you can address them with the class.

22. Continuum Line

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 10-30 minutes

Activity

1. **SET UP:** You will need a medium to large space for this activity. An open space is ideal, but not required as students will be moving around.
2. **INSTRUCTION:** Tell the class that the room is a continuum, with one wall being the “strongly agree” side and the opposite

wall being the “strongly disagree” side. Now, present an issue or open question where students must decide the extent to which they agree or disagree with the prompt. Tell them to move to their ‘position’ along the continuum.

3. Once students have found their positions on the continuum, take some time discussing the prompt and the similar or different positions.
4. This can be repeated for a variety of topics or open-ended questions.
5. **CLOSE:** Once you are done with all the prepared prompts, have students go back to their normal arrangement and continue or close the lesson.

Pointers:

This is a great large group activity that helps generate discussion, clarify concepts, and get students thinking about their own perspective in comparison to others. This is an excellent activity for opening discussions about “grey-area” concepts where opinions can differ.

Variations on the Continuum Line

- This activity usually takes 10 minutes or much more depending on the group size and number of prompts.
- Once students take their positions on the continuum you can have them discuss their perspectives with each other, have a larger class discussion where they present their opinions, or

both! Though be mindful some students may feel uncomfortable publicly demonstrating their opinion.

- Ensure you are able to facilitate the discussion respectfully, especially if discussing potentially sensitive topics. If this is the case, you may want to instruct students that if a certain topic is too overwhelming, they can step out or choose not to participate and just listen.

23. Mind Maps

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 10-30 minutes

Activity

1. **MATERIALS:** Students just need some type of writing surface and writing instrument.
2. **INSTRUCTION:** Mind maps can be integrated in teaching in so many ways and at different points of a lesson or course. Ask students to draw and identify connections between various

concepts discussed in a single class, or across multiple classes, by drawing a schematic map. This map could include key ideas, terms or sketches, with lines drawn between these entries to indicate relationships.

3. **CLOSE:** You can end the mind map activity in a variety of ways as well. If you want to assess students' understanding, consider collecting the mind maps.

Pointers:

Mind Maps are an excellent and very popular teaching technique. In particular, they can help facilitate discussion, improve collaborative thinking, connect concepts, and break down larger concepts or ideas.

Variations on Mind Maps

- You can dedicate as much time as you want to mind maps depending on the concept, students' knowledge, and the context of your lesson. They could be a 10-minute activity to a class-long activity. You can even make a mind map an assignment.
- You can easily integrate mind maps in other activities, such as having larger class discussions, having group presentations, etc.
- In addition to writing, students can develop a metaphor or draw images to simplify and explain a given concept.

- Consider sharing mind maps that students have made with each other to prompt further discussion and critical thinking.

24. Guided Note Taking

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 10-30 minutes

Activity

- Provide students with the note-taking structure, whether ahead of time by email or Web or in class as a handout.

- Present your lecture on course content using the same note-taking structure.
- As information is presented during the lecture, ensure the students are filling in missing content to complete the guided notes. You may do so by asking key questions or even asking specifically, “Based on what you have learned, what do you think goes in this spa ce?”

Pointers:

Guided Note-Taking uses the concept of **scaffolding** to provide students with a structure for taking notes during a lecture.

Scaffolding is a fundamental aspect of learning. It is the process by which individuals learn new information by building on what is known. Guided Note-Taking provides students with a format for active listening, and research suggests that being active can improve learning. Students have specific questions to answer or blanks to fill in, and this can improve their willingness and ability to pay attention. Through scaffolding, students identify the **most important concepts** introduced and begin to make distinctions between these concepts and less important ones. The information missing from the note-taking structure **is only provided during lecture**, Guided Note-Taking shows students which information is **most valuable** and gives them an **incentive to come to class** and pay attention. Thus, this can also have a

positive effect on class attendance (which typically improves performance).

25. Muddiest Point

Size: Entire class or large or small groups

Time: 10-30 minutes

Activity

- Determine what you want feedback on: the entire class session or one self-contained segment? A lecture, a discussion, a presentation?
- If you are using the technique in class, reserve a few minutes at the end of the class session. Leave enough time to ask the

question, to allow students to respond, and to collect their responses by the usual ending time.
Let students know beforehand how much time they will have to respond and what use you will make of their responses

- Pass out slips of paper or index cards for students to write on.
- Collect the responses as or before students leave. Stationing yourself at the door and collecting "muddy points" as students file out is one way; leaving a "muddy point" collection box by the exit is another.
- Respond to the students' feedback during the next class meeting or as soon as possible afterward.

Pointers:

The Muddiest Point is just about the simplest technique one can use. It is also remarkably efficient, since it provides a high information return for a very low investment of time and energy.

The technique consists of asking students to jot down a quick response to one question: "What was the muddiest point in _____?" The focus of the Muddiest Point assessment might be a lecture, a discussion, a homework assignment, a play, or a film.